Akbar, in the words of the Sanskrit poet and scholar Keshavdas, ‘duhu deen ko sahib’ (master of both religions).

While Akbar most enjoyed literary soirées during which books of Hindavi, Persian, Greek, Kashmiri, and Arabic were read out to him, in the towns of the empire it was the ghazal that was rapidly gaining popularity as the medium of choice for amateur poets. They would recite these at gatherings of aficionados which now included ‘sufis, women and general townspeople’ and brought together people from very different backgrounds. Badauni wrote that the poet Qasim Ali ‘Ghubari’ was ‘very handsome and used to sing at social gatherings and had pretentions to be a Quraishi’, but was ‘embarrassed that his father was a grocer’, showing that social mobility and the importance of lineage were both aspects of Mughal society at the time. Of the poet Qasim Kahi he was more scathing still, disapproving of his association with dervishes, courtesans and, intriguingly, dogs, though he admitted that he sang in a reasonably good voice and that some lines of his ghazals had become all the rage. These musical assemblies, or mushairas were ‘not only complex competitive arenas and technical workshops but hothouses of gossip and general social rivalry as well’, where charges of plagiarism were bitterly contested and a single excellent line of poetry would be carefully noted down by attendees and then shared widely.

Jostling alongside the translators at Fatehpur Sikri were also hundreds of artists for each document translated was to be elaborately illustrated. Akbar’s argument for his love of painting human forms, usually deemed un-Islamic, was evocatively noted by Abu’l Fazl:

> I cannot tolerate those who make the slightest criticism of this art. It seems to me that a painter is better than most in gaining a knowledge of God. Each time he draws a living being he must draw each and every limb of it, but seeing that *he* cannot bring it to life must perforce give thought to the miracle wrought by the Creator and thus obtain a knowledge of Him.

Akbar had studios built for his painters and with his usual enthusiasm and curiosity, would watch the artists at work. ‘He has built a workshop near the palace where there are studios and work rooms for the fine and more reputable arts such as painting, goldsmith work, tapestry making, carpet making and the manufacturing of arms’, wrote Monserrate. ‘Hither he frequently comes and relaxes his mind with watching at their work those